

Nobody Knows Anything

ADVENTURES IN THE SCREEN TRADE was a scathing confessional on the film industry authored by novelist and screenwriter William Goldman. His 1983 bestseller was filled with great lines, perhaps none more memorable than: “Nobody knows anything.” This quote is applicable to so much more than the film business.

Goldman was a keen inside observer of Hollywood: He won Academy Awards for *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid* (Best Original Screenplay, 1969) and for *All the President's Men* (Best Adapted Screenplay, 1976). He wrote the novel *Marathon Man*, later turned into a gripping Dustin Hoffman film (“Is it safe?”); his screenplay adaptation of Stephen King’s novel *Misery* starred Kathy Bates and James Caan (Bates won an Oscar for her performance). Perhaps most fun of all, he wrote the novel *The Princess Bride*, as well as its screenplay, which became a delightful Rob Reiner cult classic.

Goldman’s first mention of “nobody knows anything” referred to the future blockbuster movies all passed on by the studio executives. Every Hollywood studio but one (Paramount) turned down *Raiders of the Lost Ark*. It became one of the highest-grossing films of all time and was nominated for nine Academy Awards.

Columbia Pictures missed the boat with several Spielberg projects—not only *Raiders*, but they passed on *E.T.* because they had another alien film in the works (*Starman*, starring Jeff Bridges). They also passed on *Back to the Future* and *Pulp Fiction*.^{[11](#)}

Star Wars was turned down by the largest Hollywood studio at the time, Universal. As analyst Trung Phan pointed out, George Lucas’ original conception was for six films. He did not trust Hollywood, and so to make sure he had control of the film series, he asked Fox Studios for a modest